



“THE LANDLOCKED SEA IS GREEK OR ROMAN, THE BOUNDLESS SEA IS PORTUGUESE.”

Fernando Pessoa, Portuguese poet and writer, 1885–1935



Castile and Aragon

The two kingdoms of Aragon and Castile became a composite monarchy through the marriage of Ferdinand and Isabella in 1469.

infant son. In the process, not only was **Kyoto**, the imperial capital, **entirely destroyed**, but the Hosokawa and Yamana themselves became victims of the conflict, their power and status swept away as the increasingly brutal fighting continued.

The marriage in 1469 of **Isabella**, heir to the **Castilian throne** (which she inherited in 1474), and **Ferdinand**, heir to the throne of **Aragon** (which he inherited in 1479), led directly to the emergence of a **unified, unbendingly Christian Spain**. This resulted in the development of Spain as the most powerful

state in early 16th-century Europe. Isabella was 17 years old when she married Ferdinand. In choosing to marry him, she risked the wrath of her older half-brother Henry IV, who perceived her as a threat to his own power. But the marriage, in the Spanish city of Valladolid, was the beginning of an important phase of Spanish history. Within eight years, Ferdinand and Isabella—*Los Reyes Católicos*, the Catholic Monarchs—were jointly ruling Castile and Aragon, although the kingdoms were not formally unified. Administratively, politically, and financially, they remained separate and, as such, were consistently bedeviled by competing priorities and rivalries.

Even at the height of Spanish power in the 16th and early 17th centuries, no Spanish monarch was able to resolve the problem satisfactorily. Nonetheless, Spain's potential to emerge as the dominant force in Renaissance Europe was unmistakable under Ferdinand and Isabella. It was a position that the tirelessly hard-headed Isabella and the politically astute Ferdinand were well placed to exploit.



BY ABOUT 1470, PORTUGUESE exploration of the **west coast of Africa** had reached as far as modern-day Sierra Leone. It had been a hesitant process, limited by ship types, principally galleys and cogs, that were unsuited to long-range exploration. Its goals were uncertain beyond a general hope to trace the **trans-Saharan gold trade** to its source and to exploit the **West African slave trade**. The death in 1460 of **Prince Henry, “the Navigator,”** the early champion of Portuguese exploration (see 1434), had made further progress unlikely. However, in 1469 Portuguese king **Afonso V** agreed—in exchange for an annual fee—to allow a Lisbon merchant, **Fernão Gomes**, to continue to push Portuguese efforts south along the West African coast. The results were spectacular. Within five years Gomes had explored a further

2,500 MILES THE EXTENT OF THE INCA EMPIRE

2,000 miles (3,200 km) of coastline. Not only was Portugal able to lay claim to a series of what would prove immensely **lucrative trading stations** (see 1480–82) on the West African coast, Gomes also opened the way to the Portuguese penetration of the South Atlantic.

The **Inca Empire**, more short-lived even than its Aztec neighbor to the north, was formed in a surge of conquest after 1438 from its **Andean heartlands** in central Peru. **Tupac Yupanqui** (Topa Inca), who came to the Inca throne in

1471, had been made **head of the Inca armies** in 1463 and had already substantially enlarged Inca control to the north, well into modern-day Ecuador. The empire extended about 2,500 miles



Inca ruler

This 18th-century painting shows **Tupac Yupanqui** (Topa Inca), the fifth Inca of the Hanan dynasty.



Portuguese explorers

Fernão Gomes (right) continued the age of exploration begun by **Henry the Navigator** (left) as depicted in the *Monument to the Discoveries*, Lisbon.

(4,000 km). Topa Inca's principal contribution to **Inca expansion** came with his conquest from about 1470 of the Peruvian kingdom of **Chimor**.

In southeast Asia, the kingdom of **Champa** (in modern-day Vietnam) had existed since the 7th century. But in **1471 it was effectively destroyed** by Viet troops who laid waste the Champa capital, **Vijaya**. What remained of the kingdom would henceforth be a vassal state of the Vietnamese.

October 19, 1469
Marriage of Ferdinand and Isabella unites Castile and Aragon

1469 Lorenzo de Medici takes control of Florence, beginning a period rich in culture and intellectual thought

1469 Aztec empire assumes control of Aztec empire (to 1481)

October 30, 1470
Henry VI regains throne of England (to 1471)

1470 Ottomans recapture Negroponte from Venice

1470 Portuguese begin trading on Gold Coast

1470 Inca conquest of Chimor kingdom

1470 First French printing press established at Sorbonne, Paris

1471 Portuguese gain Tangier and reach Gulf of Guinea

April 11, 1471
Henry VI of England deposed for second time. Edward IV regains throne

1471 Beginning of reign of **Tupac Yupanqui** (to 1493)

1471 Collapse of Kingdom of Champa (present-day Vietnam)